



Rating
Buy

Asia
China

Technology
Software & Services

Company
GDS Holdings Ltd

Reuters
GDS.OQ

Bloomberg
GDS US

Exchange
NSM

Ticker
GDS

Date
14 Aug 2026

Forecast Change

Price at 13 Aug 2026 (USD)	34.77
Price target - 12mth (USD)	50.00
52-week range (USD)	47.52 - 29.02
HANG SENG INDEX	25,440

Strong demand trends continue

Order acceleration visible

Revenue for the quarter was up 7% YoY while adjusted EBITDA grew more slowly, rising 3% (to CNY1,406m). Adjusting for the two China spin-offs; on a pro-forma basis revenue and adjusted EBITDA would have risen 12%. GDS reported a 2Q26 net profit of CNY838m, due to a revaluation gain at Day One.

New bookings of 263MW were reported, bringing 1H to 471MW, just slightly below the 2023-25 combined add. Management expects to book 1GW for the year and to provision reservations of an extra 1GW - to prepare for follow-on demand. Orders are split evenly between cloud and AI, and come despite the company being selective in taking on business, particularly from most of the independent AI firms. The 1H bookings are split roughly one-quarter among three customers and others, and fairly evenly between existing and new markets. GDS has 1.6GW of capacity in service, 0.6GW under construction, and a 3.6GW pipeline, so the scale of the orders coming in is transformative. 235MW of move-in is expected for 2026, but the company guides for that to reach 700MW next year and around 950GW in 2028.

The company lifted area utilized by 21k square meters QoQ, which is near the high end of the 16-22k of the prior four quarters, with management saying in 1Q it expects this to reach 70k for the year. Utilized area was up 13% YoY, even with the asset monetizations taking out 15k sq. m. Utilization rate advanced 4pp QoQ to 79%.

DayOne value takes off

DayOne, has filed for an IPO and is widely [reported](#) to be seeking to raise USD5bn. The value uplift has been significant, with its January sale 6.5x the firm's investment cost. If a post money value of USD20bn is achieved, we estimate GDS will book a CNY9bn gain.

Valuation & Risks

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Key changes

Sales (FYE)	12,711 to 12,919	↑	1.6%
Op prof margin (FYE)	14.3 to 14.7	↑	3.1%
Net profit (FYE)	3,615.3 to 9,970.1	↑	175.8%

Source: Deutsche Bank



Figure 1: Funding rounds at DayOne - existing and potential

Date	Round	Capital raised (US\$bn)	Equity value (US\$bn)		GDS stake	
			Pre-money	Post-money	US\$bn	%
2026*	IPO	5	15	20	3.6	17.9%
13/1/2026	Repurchase of US\$385m shares at Series C price				2.2	23.9%
5/1/2026	Series C	2.0	7.4	9.4	2.6	28.0%
31/12/2024	Series B	1.2	2.5	3.7	1.3	35.6%
Early 2024	Series A	0.7	0.8	1.5	0.7	52.7%

* Estimated based on public information

Source : Company release, Deutsche Bank estimates, Bloomberg Finance LP

Guidance lifted

Due to the rapid order flow, the company has lifted its capex guidance for this year from CNY9bn to CNY10bn. It also lifts guidance for revenue by 1-3pp to 11.1%-13.7% and lifting adjusted EBITDA guidance by 2-3pp to 9.2%-12.9% (CNY12.7bn-13.0bn). Excluding one-time items in 1Q the mid-point would be a 6.5% gain in adjusted EBITDA. Further gains will come as it completes its follow-on offer for its C-REIT, and from the DayOne IPO.

We think current prices for GDS have become more attractive. We stick with our USD50 per share valuation which is DCF based, and retain our BUY rating (see page 4 for Valuation & Risk details).



Quarterly financials

Figure 2: Results summary

Income Statement (CNY m)	2Q25	3Q25	4Q25	1Q26	2Q26	YoY	QoQ	Comment
Total revenue	2,900	2,887	2,922	3,367	3,088	6.5%	-8.3%	PF rev +12% in 1H
Cost of sales	(1,355)	(1,387)	(1,424)	(1,404)	(1,572)	16.1%	12.0%	
Selling and marketing	(34)	(40)	(42)	(37)	(32)	-5.2%	-11.9%	
General and admin	(232)	(228)	(199)	(177)	(186)	-19.8%	4.7%	
Research and development	(9)	(8)	(8)	(10)	(7)	-20.0%	-26.2%	
EBITDA	1,271	1,223	1,248	1,740	1,291	1.5%	-25.8%	
Adj EBITDA	1,372	1,342	1,366	1,949	1,406	2.5%	-27.9%	PF adj EBITDA +13% in 1H
Adj gross profit	1,510	1,473	1,478	1,952	1,499	-0.7%	-23.2%	
Deprn & Amort	(857)	(861)	(885)	(832)	(851)	-0.6%	2.4%	
Operating profit	415	362	363	908	439	5.9%	-51.6%	
Others inc. asset sales	11	1,385	(1,621)	96	19	77.8%	-80.4%	
EBIT	425	1,747	(1,257)	1,004	458	7.7%	-54.4%	
EBIT margin	14.7%	60.5%	-43.0%	29.8%	14.8%			
Finance costs	(405)	(375)	(413)	(380)	(367)	-9.4%	-3.4%	
Associates	(26)	(461)	1,231	2,137	960			DayOne disposal gains
Taxation	(65)	(182)	(23)	(109)	(214)	229.2%	96.4%	
Minority interest, preferred div	(15)	(16)	(18)	(28)	(35)	126.9%	24.5%	
Net Profit Attributable	(86)	712	(481)	2,624	803	-1034.4%	-69.4%	
Revenue	2,900	2,887	2,922	3,367	3,088	6.5%	-8.3%	
Adjusted EBITDA	1,372	1,342	1,366	1,949	1,406	2.5%	-27.9%	
Area under construction/acq.	sqm	132,235	72,764	73,994	118,411	170,355	28.8%	43.9%
Area in service	sqm	618,060	653,762	668,283	674,269	684,977	10.8%	1.6%
Total capacity	sqm	750,295	726,526	742,277	792,680	855,332	14.0%	7.9%
Total area committed	sqm	663,959	656,728	670,106	725,485	784,801	18.2%	8.2%
Area utilized (EoP)	sqm	479,186	486,607	504,843	520,929	542,236	13.2%	4.1%
Utilization	%	77.5%	74.4%	75.5%	77.3%	79.2%	1.6%	1.9%
New area utilized	sqm	16,763	7,421	18,236	16,086	21,307	27.1%	32.5%
MSR (monthly service revenue)	Rmb/sqm	2,052	1,992	1,964	2,188	1,936	-5.7%	-11.5%

Source : Deutsche Bank, company data

Valuation and earnings forecast changes

We adjust our estimates to reflect guidance, and include estimated upcoming gains from its pending China follow-on and Day One IPO. While our DCF valuation has edged upwards, we stick with our USD50 price target for now.

Figure 3: Earnings forecast changes

Annual	Reported			DB Estimates		DB prior est.		Variance		YoY change			DB vs. cons	
Key Revenue Metric	FY23	FY24	FY25	FY26E	FY27E	FY26E	FY27E	FY26E	FY27E	FY25	FY26E	FY27E	FY26E	FY27E
Operating Revenue	9,957	10,322	11,432	12,919	15,207	12,711	14,797	2%	3%	11%	13%	18%	2%	9%
Cost and profitability														
Cost	5,882	5,927	6,467	7,359	8,741	7,240	8,505	2%	3%	9%	14%	19%		
EBITDA	4,074	4,395	4,965	5,560	6,466	5,471	6,292	2%	3%	13%	12%	16%	-6%	3%
EBITDA margin	40.9%	42.6%	43.4%	43.0%	42.5%	43.0%	42.5%	0.0%	0.0%	2%	-1%	-1%		
EBIT	555	1,152	1,505	1,900	1,835	1,813	1,666	5%	10%	31%	26%	-3%	4%	-2%
Net Profit	(4,344)	3,371	895	9,970	726	3,615	601	176%	21%	-73%	1014%	-93%	149%	-64%

Source : DB estimates, Bloomberg Finance LP consensus, company releases

Key downside risks include: 1) Interest rates rising, lifting earnings pressure; 2) Over-investment tendencies returning; 3) Spot pricing declining; and 4) Bloomberg reported just before 2Q25 quarter's results that ST Telemedia is considering selling its 30% stake, and cut that to 27% in mid-September via a block trade. It is locked up for six months, and could find a buyer for the rest, but this is complicated by the firm's VIE structure and dual-class voting shares.



Figure 4: DCF estimates

DCF	2025	2026E	2027E	2028E	2029E	2030E	2031E	2032E	2033E	2034E	2035E
Risk free rate		2.0%		Terminal growth estimate							
Beta		1.20		inflation estimate		0.50%	RFR less term premium				
Mkt risk premium		6.0%		Discount for over-earning		0.0%	ROE-WACC partial convergence formula				
Cost of equity		9.2%		Productivity fade		-1.5%	Productivity-like return decay as IDCs age				
Interest post tax cost (LT money)		3.4%		Terminal growth		-1.0%					
Gearing (long term debt/ equity value)		20%									
WACC		8.0%									
Unlevered DCF (in USDm)											
Unlevered FCF		870	(1,342)	(980)	353	782	1,044	1,320	1,552	1,690	1,796
EV		12,686	12,835	15,208	17,411	18,456	19,157	19,653	19,912	19,960	19,874
Starting net debt (ex CBs)		(1,716)	(708)	(2,221)	(3,411)	(3,298)	(4,630)	(3,989)	(3,100)	(2,024)	(844)
Value of equity		10,970	12,126	12,987	14,000	15,158	14,528	15,664	16,812	17,936	19,030
Per share (HKD)		51.4	56.7	60.7	65.4	70.9	67.9	73.2	78.6	83.8	89.0
Per ADS (USD)		52.7	58.1	62.3	67.1	72.7	69.7	75.1	80.6	86.0	91.2
EV/EBITDA		16.0	13.9	13.3	12.1	10.9	10.1	9.2	8.5	8.0	7.5
DY at DCF value		0.0%	0.0%	0.0%	0.0%	0.9%	1.2%	1.4%	1.7%	1.9%	2.0%
PE at DCF value		7.0	106.5	91.3	42.2	26.6	21.3	18.1	14.9	13.4	12.5

Source : Deutsche Bank estimates



Guidance and strategy

2026 guidance (revised up in 2Q26)

- Revenue of CNY12,700m-13,000m (up 11.1%-13.7%)
- Adjusted EBITDA of CNY5,900m-6,100m (up 69.2%-12.9%)
- Capex of CNY10,000m

The China build-out - and how to fund it

The dominant theme remains the 1Q26 pivot towards capturing the "multi-year growth story" of AI, as the company looks to help customers with their gigawatt-scale deployments. To meet this demand, GDS in 1Q26 outlined a three-year business plan to invest CNY30bn to CNY50bn. Management says this will result in net debt/EBITDA rising to 5-6x. While this will shake out some investors, we expect the market to slowly warm to this change.

The acceleration in build-out was evident in 4Q when the company announced plans to enter Inner Mongolia, Ningxia, and Shaoguan (in Northern Guangdong), each among the eight national computing hub nodes in China's "Eastern Data, Western Computing" policy. The policy focuses on moving hyperscaler activity to the West, while connecting the hubs with high-speed, high-capacity trunk capacity. The telcos built a lot of capacity in these more distant hubs, which made it difficult to profit, but demand is coming through, so GDS is ready to compete outside of its initial focus of in-and-around Tier 1 cities. The ramp-up already seems to be lined up, with GDS noting it has 3.7GW equivalent of land and power reservations.

Management noted that agreements getting signed commit to a certain capacity, which the company records as "bookings" while the rest of the site is reserved for the customer's subsequent growth, with follow-up orders over the next one-to-two years "almost certain".

Management has noted a build-out cost of around CNY20m per MW, and for that to drive around 10-11% adjusted gross profit yield (revenue less cash opex/gross PP&E). We would assume the targeted utilization would be around 90% - but this has not been stated. This compares with its current portfolio generating 11% at 75% utilization. The company provided such details, as MSR comes down along with development costs as more remote/larger scale sites are built out. It was also noted that price per GW to build out has dropped around 15% in the last three years due to lower cost for mechanical & electrical plant.

The company plans to fund its build-out using 60% debt funding. So at the CNY40bn mid-point of capex, that would mean CNY24bn of debt. It looks to fund the remaining CNY16bn of equity using a mix of CFO (last year CNY3bn), and asset monetizations.

The build-out is simplified following the company's raising of CNY3.5bn in 2025 from its China monetizations, and in the process creating a self-funding mechanism through its C-REIT. That REIT has been trading on a 3-4% dividend yield, yet the company can generate an IRR of low- to mid-teens pre-gearing, or in the 20s post gearing, making for a lucrative asset-development arbitrage - at least while the



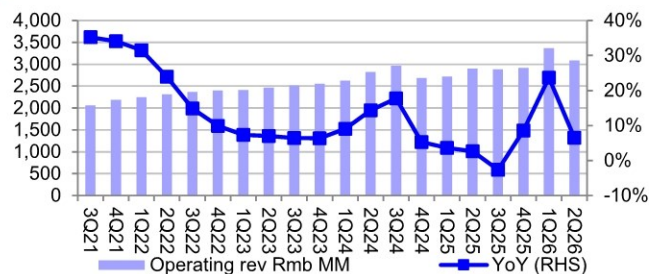
demand-supply situation is favourable - as it is now. The company aims to off-load CNY4-6bn of assets in 2026, and received CNY2.7bn from a Day One sell-down in 1Q.

The scale of demand and its build-out has led GDS to target 500 to 800 megawatts of new bookings annually, which is substantial relative to 1.9GW of capacity at quarter end. Year-to-date, the company has already secured over 340MW, indicating strong momentum towards its full-year 2026 target of at least 500MW. This compares with 300MW in 2025, which in turn was triple the recent annual run rate.



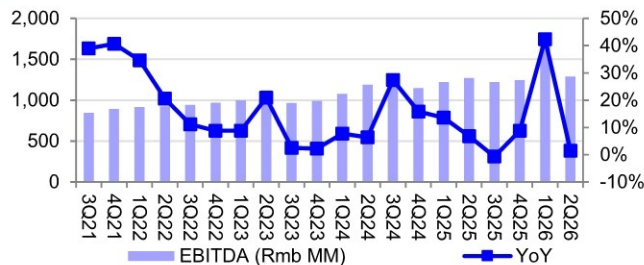
Quarterly charts

Figure 5: Total revenue



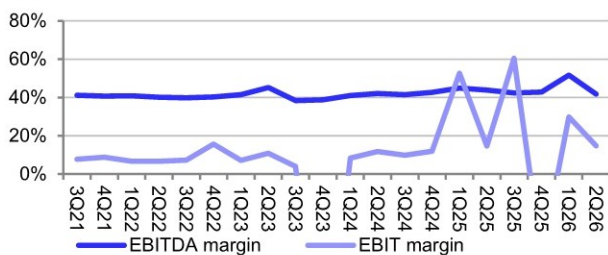
Source : Deutsche Bank, company data

Figure 6: EBITDA



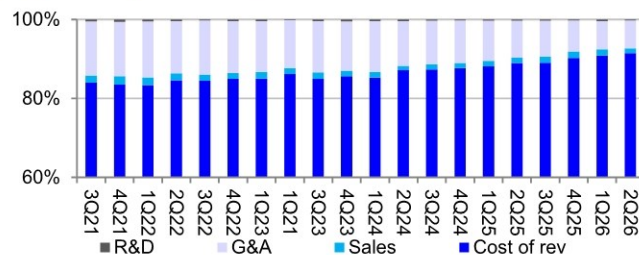
Source : Deutsche Bank, company data

Figure 7: EBITDA/EBIT margins



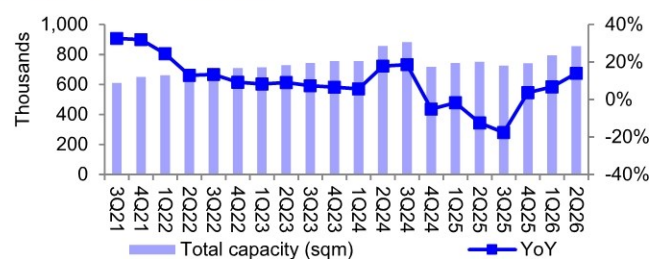
Source : Deutsche Bank, company data

Figure 8: Opex breakdown



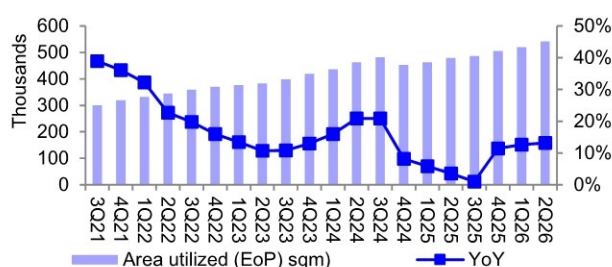
Source : Deutsche Bank, company data

Figure 9: Total capacity



Source : Deutsche Bank, company data

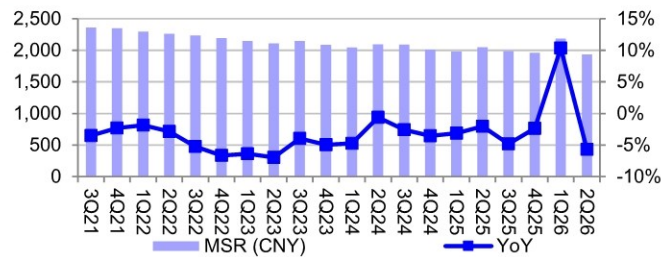
Figure 10: Area utilized



Source : Deutsche Bank, company data

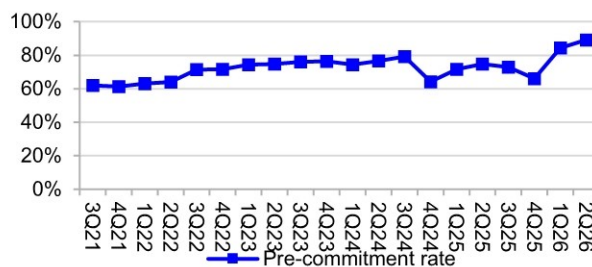


Figure 11: Monthly service revenue



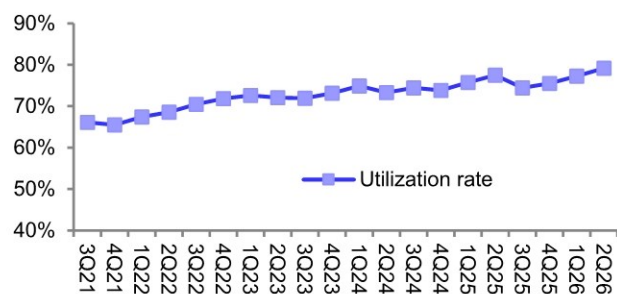
Source : Deutsche Bank, company data

Figure 12: Pre-commitment rates



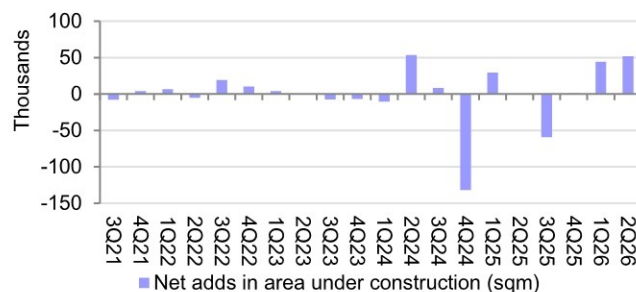
Source : Deutsche Bank, company data

Figure 13: Utilization rate



Source : Deutsche Bank, company data

Figure 14: Net adds in area under construction



Source : Deutsche Bank, company data

Acknowledgement

We would like to thank Sylvia Chen of Evalueserve for her help in preparing this report.



Model updated: 13 August 2026

Running the numbers

Asia

China

Software & Services

GDS Holdings Ltd

Reuters: GDS.OQ

Bloomberg: GDS US

Buy

Price (13 Aug 26) USD 34.77

Target Price USD 50.00

52 Week range USD 29.02 - 47.52

Market cap (m) USDm 7,236.3
EURm 6,269.3

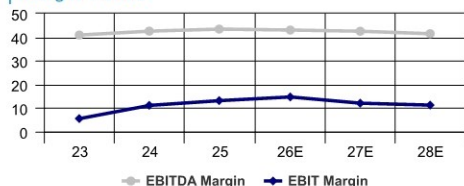
Company Profile

GDS is a leading independent developer and operator of data centers for the China market. It focuses on sites in the largest cities and serves hyperscale and other customers. It has a mixture of self-owned and leased sites and is starting to add data centers outside the mainland to support its customers' build outs.

Price Performance



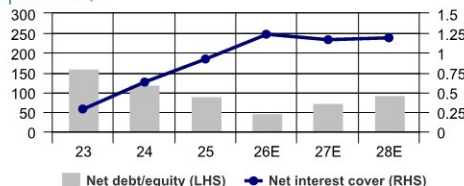
Margin Trends



Growth & Profitability



Solvency



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Fiscal year end 31-Dec

Financial Summary

	2023	2024	2025	2026E	2027E	2028E
DB EPS (CNY)	-22.22	-4.51	-7.14	35.89	-0.11	0.75
Reported EPS (CNY)	-22.22	-4.51	4.36	47.91	3.48	4.35
DPS (CNY)	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00
BVPS (CNY)	101.1	120.2	135.7	188.1	191.9	196.7
Weighted average shares (m)	195	184	206	208	209	209
Average market cap (CNYm)	19,343	16,734	46,524	48,817	48,817	48,817
Enterprise value (CNYm)	49,772	43,821	71,575	66,827	77,427	85,764

Valuation Metrics

P/E (DB) (x)	nm	nm	nm	6.5	nm	311.5
P/E (Reported) (x)	nm	nm	52.0	4.9	67.3	53.9
P/BV (x)	0.64	1.42	1.85	1.25	1.22	1.19
FCF Yield (%)	nm	13.8	nm	9.9	nm	nm
Dividend Yield (%)	0.0	0.0	0.0	0.0	0.0	0.0
EV/Sales (x)	5.0	4.2	6.3	5.2	5.1	4.4
EV/EBITDA (x)	12.2	10.0	14.4	12.0	12.0	10.7
EV/EBIT (x)	89.7	38.0	47.5	35.2	42.2	39.5

Income Statement (CNYm)

Sales revenue	9,957	10,322	11,432	12,919	15,207	19,300
Gross profit	5,442	5,466	6,045	6,740	7,853	9,762
EBITDA	4,074	4,395	4,965	5,560	6,466	8,004
Depreciation	3,520	3,243	3,459	3,660	4,630	5,831
Amortisation	0	0	0	0	0	0
EBIT	555	1,152	1,505	1,900	1,835	2,173
Net interest income(expense)	-1,939	-1,835	-1,635	-1,538	-1,574	-1,827
Associates/affiliates	0	0	716	7,959	110	226
Exceptionals/extraordinaries	0	0	2,364	2,500	750	750
Other pre-tax income/(expense)	-2,915	68	-1,522	1	1	1
Profit before tax	-4,300	-615	1,429	10,822	1,122	1,324
Income tax expense	-15	156	470	716	253	275
Minorities	5	6	10	10	10	10
Other post-tax income/(expense)	-54	-54	-54	-126	-133	-133
Net profit	-4,344	-831	895	9,970	726	907
DB adjustments (including dilution)	0	0	-2,364	-2,500	-750	-750
DB Net profit	-4,344	-831	-1,469	7,470	-24	157

Cash Flow (CNYm)

Cash flow from operations	-278	5,314	3,196	13,778	5,791	5,295
Net Capex	-6,326	-3,009	-4,706	-8,940	-16,449	-13,643
Free cash flow	-6,603	2,305	-1,510	4,837	-10,658	-8,348
Equity raised/(bought back)	0	0	0	0	0	0
Dividends paid	0	0	0	0	0	0
Net inc/(dec) in borrowings	4,454	-3,151	3,635	200	6,837	5,200
Other investing/financing cash flows	-1,713	-7,723	-3,266	103	58	11
Net cash flow	-3,862	-8,569	-1,141	5,140	-3,763	-3,137
Change in working capital	646	-1,208	-1,056	264	571	-1,269

Balance Sheet (CNYm)

Cash and other liquid assets	7,711	7,868	14,306	21,556	17,803	14,675
Tangible fixed assets	47,499	40,204	38,054	43,451	55,406	63,392
Goodwill/intangible assets	7,765	6,367	5,461	5,461	5,461	5,461
Associates/investments	0	0	0	0	0	0
Other assets	11,471	19,209	22,178	23,626	25,417	27,924
Total assets	74,447	73,649	79,998	94,094	104,087	111,453
Interest bearing debt	37,975	34,824	38,459	38,659	45,496	50,696
Other liabilities	17,413	16,236	14,859	18,774	21,194	22,443
Total liabilities	55,388	51,061	53,318	57,434	66,690	73,139
Shareholders' equity	18,893	22,458	25,783	35,753	36,480	37,387
Minorities	166	130	897	907	917	927
Total shareholders' equity	19,059	22,588	26,680	36,660	37,396	38,313
Net debt	30,264	26,957	24,153	17,103	27,693	36,021

Key Company Metrics

Sales growth (%)	6.8	3.7	10.8	13.0	17.7	26.9
DB EPS growth (%)	-185.6	79.7	-58.5	na	na	na
EBITDA Margin (%)	40.9	42.6	43.4	43.0	42.5	41.5
EBIT Margin (%)	5.6	11.2	13.2	14.7	12.1	11.3
Payout ratio (%)	nm	nm	0.0	0.0	0.0	0.0
ROE (%)	-20.7	-4.0	3.7	32.4	2.0	2.5
Capex/sales (%)	63.5	29.2	41.2	69.2	108.2	70.7
Capex/depreciation (x)	1.8	0.9	1.4	2.4	3.6	2.3
Net debt/equity (%)	158.8	119.3	90.5	46.7	74.1	94.0
Net interest cover (x)	0.3	0.6	0.9	1.2	1.2	1.2

Source: Company data, Deutsche Bank estimates



Appendix 1

Important Disclosures

*Other information available upon request

Disclosure checklist			
Company	Ticker	Recent price*	Disclosure
GDS Holdings Ltd	GDS.OQ	32.74 (USD) 12 Aug 2026	NA

*Prices are current as of the end of the previous trading session unless otherwise indicated and are sourced from local exchanges via Reuters, Bloomberg and other vendors. Other information is sourced from Deutsche Bank, subject companies, and other sources. For disclosures pertaining to recommendations or estimates made on securities other than the primary subject of this research, please see the most recently published company report or visit our global disclosure look-up page on our website at <https://research.db.com/Research/Disclosures/EquityResearchDisclosures>. Aside from within this report, important risk and conflict disclosures can also be found at <https://research.db.com/Research/Disclosures/Disclaimer>. Investors are strongly encouraged to review this information before investing.

Important Disclosures Required by U.S. Regulators

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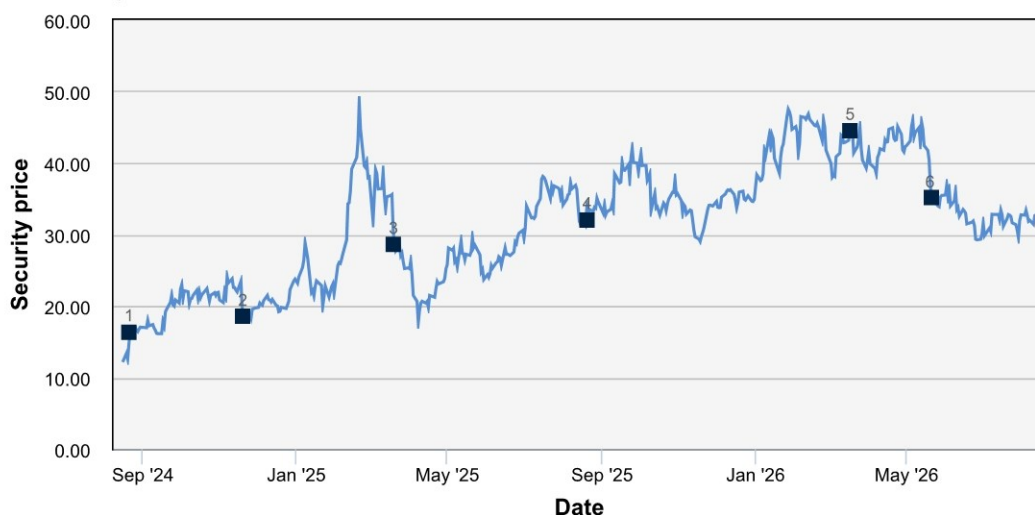
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Historical recommendations and target price: GDS Holdings Ltd (GDS.OQ)

(as of 08/12/2026)



Current Recommendations

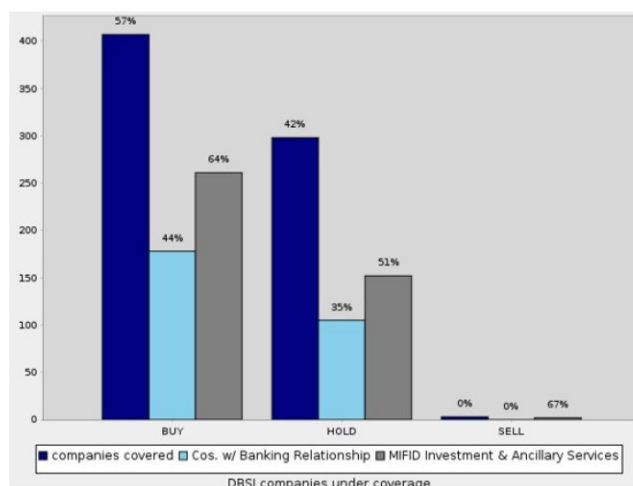
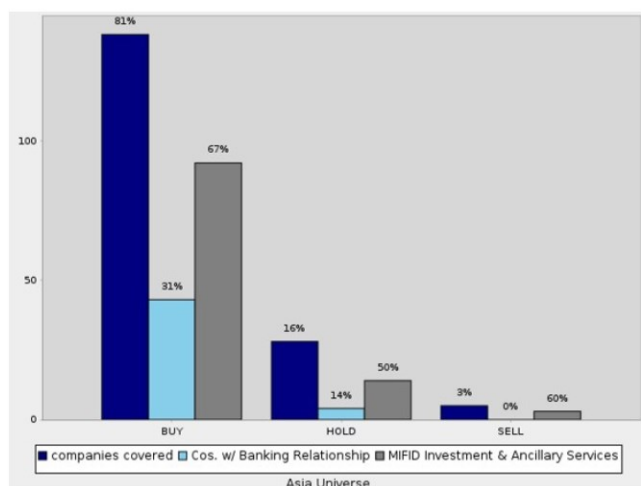
Buy
Hold
Sell
Not Rated
Suspended Rating

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1.	08/22/2024	Buy, Target Price Change USD 17.00, Current Price USD 16.30 Peter Milliken, CFA	4.	08/21/2025	Buy, Target Price Change USD 40.00, Current Price USD 32.00 Peter Milliken, CFA
2.	11/20/2024	Buy, Target Price Change USD 26.00, Current Price USD 18.57 Peter Milliken, CFA	5.	03/18/2026	Buy, Target Price Change USD 48.00, Current Price USD 44.49 Peter Milliken, CFA
3.	03/20/2025	Buy, Target Price Change USD 38.00, Current Price USD 28.62 Peter Milliken, CFA	6.	05/21/2026	Buy, Target Price Change USD 50.00, Current Price USD 35.16 Peter Milliken, CFA



Equity rating dispersion and banking relationships



Equity Rating and Dispersion Key

The Equity Rating Dispersion Chart depicts the following:

The proportion of recommendations that are rated "buy", "sell" and "hold" over the previous 12 months. This is shown for securities issued in the stated region e.g. "Europe Universe". See rating definitions below. This is represented by the "Companies Covered" bars in the chart. The percentage value displayed above the bar is the proportion as a percentage. E.g. 50% above the "buy" / "Companies Covered" bar means that 50% of DB's equity research covered companies over the past 12 months have a "buy" rating.

Next to each of the three respective bars showing the proportion of "buy", "sell" and "hold" recommendations we provide two additional bars to show:

- The proportion of "buy", "sell" or "hold" recommendations where Deutsche Bank and/or Affiliates provided MIFID Investment or Ancillary Services in the past 12 months. This is represented in the "MIFID Investment and Ancillary Services" bar. The percentage value displayed above the bar shows the proportion of Companies Covered with the given rating where DB has also provided MIFID Investment and Ancillary Services in the past 12 months. E.g. 50% above the "Cos. w/ MIFID Investment and Ancillary Services" bar means 50% of the Companies Covered with the rating stated have also received MIFID Investment and Ancillary Services from DB.

- The proportion of "buy" (or "sell" or "hold") recommendations where Deutsche Bank and/or Affiliates has provided Investment Banking services in the past 12 months for which it has received compensation. The percentage value displayed above the bar shows the proportion of Companies Covered with the stated rating where DB has also provided Investment Banking services in the past 12 months. E.g. 50% above the "Cos. w/ Investment Banking relationship" bar means 50% of the Companies Covered with the rating stated also have an Investment Banking Relationship with DB.

Buy: Based on a current 12-month view of TSR, we recommend that investors buy the stock.

Sell: Based on a current 12-month view of TSR, we recommend that investors sell the stock.

Hold: We take a neutral view on the stock 12-months out and, based on this time horizon, do not recommend either a Buy or Sell.

TSR = Total Shareholder Return. Percentage change in share price from current price to projected target price plus projected dividend yield

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